documents that contextualized the issues flagged in the original one. He sent these to his two co-authors and JRD.

The first was titled ‘Strategic Plans for Tatas’ (or ‘Tata Plan’) and the second, ‘Issues Which Need to Be Addressed’. The former, as the title suggested, was an impassioned plea to the chairman to formulate a Strategic Plan. Ratan wrote: ‘I am strongly advocating the initiation of such a document by the Chairman, as I personally see signs of our disintegration as a group.’

The Tata Plan outlined three goals. The first was the laying down of a ‘long-term direction’ for existing and future activities, including product areas and international operations. This was at the heart of the document.

The second was to recommend the reversal of the ‘increasing tendency for the development and growth’ of ‘business activity’ being determined by the ‘framework of individual operating companies’. This was necessary as there was no common set of guidelines to determine the ‘business areas into which [the] Tatas should go or develop further’.

The third was the laying down of operating guidelines for ‘growth, earning, technology utilization, R&D, industrial relations and employee benefits’. Ratan underlined the need to define the group structure that needed to be established to meet its goals. This would cover the issues of hiving off underperforming companies, amalgamation of entities involved in related businesses and the creation of new companies to undertake new lines of business.

While considering all these aspects, Ratan said that the first issue that required consideration was the future relations between the promoter, Tata Sons, and the companies. A conscious decision had to be taken whether in the ‘next 5 to 10 years’ the Tatas should encourage more autonomy and function as a disparate group of companies loosely connected to each other, or achieve unity. The former approach would mean that the group would become a ‘loosely connected agglomeration of independent companies, where resources are duplicated, where competition in similar product areas takes place, and where divergence of operating philosophies exist’. If, however, a decision was taken for the organization to operate as a group, ‘then several strategic decisions would need to be taken relating to the projected organisational and operational structure of the Tatas’, Ratan emphasized.